transcends our little mortality," he tells me. "I think a lot of people at some level—again, either explicitly or implicitly—will do science or art or something because of the sense that you do get to transcend something. You touch something eternal. That word, eternal: very important. It's very, very, very important."

Freeman Dyson had hoped to find a way to preserve intelligent life for all time. His 1979 paper proposed a way to propagate some kind of intelligent machine into an infinite future, through a scheme involving the constant slowing of processing and intermittent hibernation. Unfortunately, those calculations were done under the assumption that the universe's expansion doesn't accelerate, and now, it appears that it does. And if the acceleration continues, Dyson's plan won't work. "It would be disappointing," he admits. "I mean, you have to accept what nature provides. It's like the fact that we have finite lifetimes. It's not so tragic. In many, many ways it makes the universe more interesting. It's always evolving to something different. But having a finite lifetime for the whole thing … maybe that's our fate. But certainly, I would prefer to have evolution going on forever."

And who knows? Maybe there's a sense in which it does. Roger Penrose thinks there's a better way. He's spent the last decade or so developing his Conformal Cyclic Cosmology, which postulates a universe cycling from Big Bang to Heat Death, over and over again, forever, with the tantalizing possibility that something—some imprint from a previous cycle—might make it through the transition. The notion that what passes through could contain meaningful information about any conscious inhabitants is just idle speculation at the moment, he says, but the implications of that possibility could be profound. "I'm not certainly saying that I think this, but in some ways I find it less depressing … that maybe after one's death, it's conceivable there could be some legacy."

Or maybe the possibility of a multiverse landscape can comfort us. Jonathan Pritchard, a cosmologist at Imperial College London whose work has run the gamut from cosmic inflation to the evolution of galaxies, finds hope in the idea that in some other distant, unconnected region, something might exist long after we're nothing but waste heat. "Somewhere out there, there is a multiverse where stuff is always going on," he says. "Emotionally, I like the idea of that."

But *we* still die, I say.

He's unfazed. "It's not all about us, you know."